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Volume XXXII Number 49; For the week Dec 4-10, 2007, released on Dec 3

• Editorial Office: Living Media India Ltd., F-14/15, Connaught Place New Delhi 110001. Phones: 23315801-4.

Fax: 23316180, Cable: Livmedia, New Delhi.

• Subscriptions: For assistance contact Customer Care India Today Group, A-61, Sector-57, Noida (P) 201301.

Phones: Toll-free number: 1800 1800 100 (from BSNL/MTNL lines), (91) 201 2479900 from Delhi and

Faridabad; (0120) 2479900 from Rest of India (Monday-Friday, 10 a.m.-6 p.m.). Fax: (0120) 4078080,

e-mail: ircare@indiatoday.com; Mumbai: 022-2444423-6, Fax: 24444358. • Sales: Direct all trade enquiries to

General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited, 201 Connaught Place, F-14, Middle Circle, Connaught Place,

New Delhi. • Regd. Office: K-9 Connaught Circus, New Delhi 110001. • Impact Offices: Trade Centre, 2nd Floor,

Kamala City, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Parel, Mumbai 400013. Phone: 24983355, Fax: 24982266. • Hamilton

House, 1-A, Connaught Place, New Delhi 110001. Phone: 23322233, Fax: 23327330. • 98-A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai,

2nd Floor, Mylapore, Chennai-600 004. Phones: 28478526-41, Telex: 041-6177, Int'l. In. Fax: 28472178, Cable:

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22212448, 22213037, 22218343, Fax: 22218335, Cable: Livmedia, Bangalore. • 52, Jawaharlal Nehru Road,

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• 24, "Suryarath Bldg", 2nd Floor, Behind White House, Panchwati, Office C.G. Road, Ahmedabad-380006,

Phone: 26540393, 26540929, Fax: 26565293.

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India Ltd., 18-35 Milestone, Delhi Mathura Road, Faridabad-121007, (Haryana); at Thomson Press India Ltd.,

A-9, Industrial Complex, Maraimalai Nagar, District Kancheepuram-603209, (Tamil Nadu), and at Thomson Press

India Ltd., Plot No. 5-5A, TTC Industrial Area, Thane, Belapur Road, Airoli, Navi Mumbai-400708, (Maharashtra).

Published at K-9, Connaught Circus, New Delhi-110001.

• India Today does not take responsibility for returning unsolicited publication material

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There has been a dramatic turn of events in Pakistan. It began with the sudden return of Nawaz Sharif for the second time in just over two months, adding to Pakistan's already boiling cauldron of political intrigue. In early September, Sharif had touched down in Pakistan only to be deported within a matter of a few hours. The imposition of a state of Emergency, the suspension of the judiciary, arrests of opposition leaders and the news of troop defections in the north seemed to indicate that Pakistan was trapped in a political stalemate.

But things have changed quickly with the foxy General Pervez Musharraf pulling off another surprising U-turn with enough drama to keep everybody guessing. It is being said Saudi Arabia twisted Musharraf's arm to allow Sharif to return. It then set in motion a chain of events that has left everything up in the air again. Sharif's main political rival Benazir Bhutto is already in Pakistan, vying for power, and strongly rumoured to have brokered a deal with Musharraf. For his part, Musharraf has given up his uniform, once again displaying his ferocious instinct for survival.

Pakistan is now set for general elections in January and Bhutto and Sharif have returned to the centrestage of their country's politics. Even though they are both former prime ministers accused of corruption and misrule, they have inadvertently come to represent a democratic Pakistan, however fractious or flawed that democracy may be.

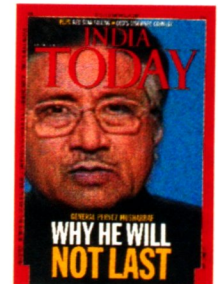
Much has yet to be put in place in Pakistan to ensure free and fair polls. The Emergency has to be lifted and the powers of the judiciary restored, an independent election commission set up and some of the overriding powers of the President revoked. Now Pakistan can at least hope that its future will be decided by the balance established between the old troika of president, prime minister and army chief.

Our cover story this week, reported by Hasan Zaidi, our regular contributor from Karachi, looks at the two main contenders for political power Begum Bhutto and Mian Sharif and how they can shape the political destiny of Pakistan in the run up to the general elections.

This issue also features an incredible story from far-off Mizoram that repeats itself once every 48 years with the flowering of a particular species of bamboo. The appearance of the bamboo fruit so severely upsets the ecological balance of the area that it leads to famines and in the past has even led to political upheaval. Principal Correspondent Swagata Sen travelled extensively across a state grappling with this cruel twist of nature to bring us a very unusual story.

I am also happy to announce that we have also relaunched our website www.indiatoday.com. The new-look website will have all our magazine's content, the INDIA TODAY emagazine, special web-only features, blogs by our in-house specialists and a lot more reader interactivity. I am sure you will enjoy reading INDIA TODAY online. Check it out.

(Aroon Purie)



Our Nov 2007 cover